

Early Access as a Strategic Development Model in the Modern Game Industry



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I. About us.

The company selected for this analysis is Grinding Gear Games. Grinding Gear Games was a studio game founded in November 2006 in Auckland, New Zealand, by a team with diverse backgrounds including artificial intelligence, software security, industrial design, and competitive game play. The studio describes itself as being built by veterans of online role-playing games who understand the importance of visceral combat and a complex item economy. That background is important because it shows that the company's identity has always been tied to deep systems rather than simple one-off experiences. Grinding Gear Games is best known for Path of Exile, and the studio is currently supporting both Path of Exile and Path of Exile 2.



Figure 1: Official Grinding Gear Games logo.

II. What is this trend.

In the modern game industry, many games are no longer simple products that can be fully polished behind closed doors and then released once. This is especially true for multiplayer, live service, and systems heavy games, where balance, progression, retention, and community response shape the experience over time. Because of this, Early Access has become more than a marketing tool. It is now a strategic development model that helps studios test complex systems with real players before full release.

This trend matters most for games where the hardest design problems only appear at scale. Internal testing can find bugs and obvious usability issues, but it cannot fully simulate real player behavior, social meta formation, or long term engagement. For these reasons, Early Access is increasingly used as a core part of development rather than as a final promotional step.

III. Why does this trend exist.

Early Access has become more important because modern games are increasingly complex and difficult to perfect before launch. Many contemporary titles are built around interconnected systems such as progression, balance, economy, matchmaking, and long-term retention. These systems may appear functional in internal testing, but they often behave very differently once large numbers of real players begin interacting with them in unexpected ways.

For this reason, studios can no longer rely only on closed development and late-stage polishing. They need access to real player behavior earlier in the process. Early Access responds to this need by turning release into a stage of learning rather than a final endpoint. It allows developers to gather feedback, identify hidden design problems, and refine systems while the game is still evolving. In that sense, the rise of Early Access reflects a broader shift in the industry: many games today are not simply finished and delivered, but gradually shaped through ongoing interaction between developers and players.

IV. Why Early Access fits heavy-balance games more than story games

Although Early Access can benefit many kinds of games, it is especially effective for systems-heavy titles. Games built around combat balance, build diversity, itemization, progression loops, or long-term retention often contain problems that only become visible at scale. Real players expose dominant strategies, weak rewards, pacing frustrations, and community-driven meta shifts that are difficult to predict in internal tests alone.

This makes Early Access particularly valuable for genres such as action RPGs, competitive multiplayer games, and live-service titles. In these cases, player behavior is not just feedback after development; it becomes part of the development process itself. By contrast, story-driven or tightly authored games may gain less from a long public iteration period, because their core strengths usually depend more on narrative structure, pacing, and presentation than on constant systemic rebalancing. As a result, Early Access should not be seen as equally necessary for every game, but as a strategy that is most useful when a game's quality depends on deep system refinement over time.

V. Path of Exile 2 as the strongest example.

Yes. Grinding Gear Games strongly follows this trend, especially through Path of Exile and Path of Exile 2.

Grinding Gear Games is a New Zealand studio known for action RPGs built around deep character customization, item systems, and long term live support. This makes the company a strong example of a studio that benefits from Early Access as a core development strategy.

Path of Exile 2 is particularly suited to this model because it is highly systems driven. Its combat balance, class building, itemization, progression, and economy are too complex to perfect through internal testing alone. These are exactly the kinds of systems that require real player data and ongoing iteration.

Grinding Gear Games appears to use Early Access in three main ways. First, it uses player feedback to improve balance and overall feel. Small changes to loot rates, skill power, or progression speed can dramatically affect an action RPG. Second, it uses the pre release period to test economy and retention, which are essential for a game built around replayability. Third, it already operates with the communication and update rhythm of a live service studio before full release. This shows that Early Access is not an extra step for the company. It is part of how the game is developed.

VI. Deadlock as a controlled variation of the same strategy

Deadlock also supports this argument, even though it is not using a fully public Early Access model. Valve has presented the game as still being in early development, with temporary art and experimental gameplay, while access remains limited. Even so, the logic is similar.

Deadlock is a competitive, system-dependent game, so real players are needed to reveal issues with mechanics, tactics, onboarding, and balance before full release.



Figure 2: Deadlock promotional image.

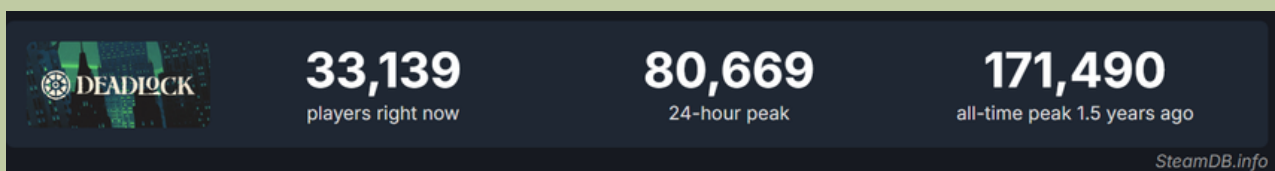


Figure 3: Deadlock player count statistics on SteamDB.

VII. Concord and Highguard as warning cases.

Concord and Highguard can be used as warning cases, although they should not be treated as direct proof that the lack of Early Access alone causes failure. Instead, they suggest that live service and retention sensitive games face significant risk when public iteration is too short, too closed, or treated mainly as marketing.

A brief beta can help with server testing and awareness, but it is not the same as sustained community led development. For games that depend on long term engagement, public iteration needs to be meaningful enough to expose deeper design problems before launch.

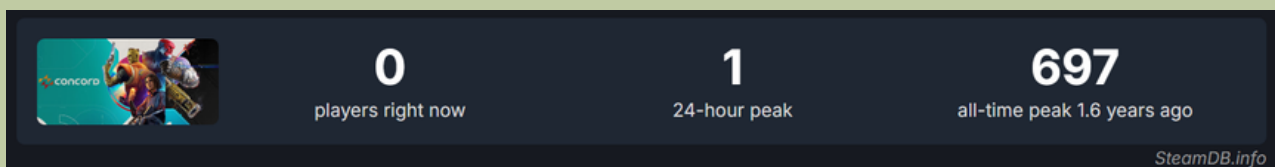


Figure 4: Concord player count statistics on SteamDB.

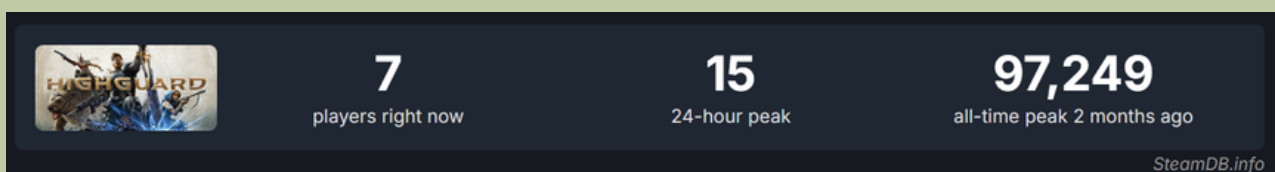


Figure 5: Highguard player count statistics on SteamDB.

VIII. Conclusion.

Early Access has become an important strategic development model because it helps studios test real player behavior, refine complex systems, and build communities before full release. It is especially useful for games that are balance heavy, economy heavy, or retention sensitive.

Grinding Gear Games clearly follows this trend. With Path of Exile 2, the studio uses Early Access not simply as promotion, but as a core part of development. This fits the company well because its games depend on deep iteration, long term engagement, and constant system refinement.

Overall, the rise of Early Access reflects a wider shift in the game industry. Many modern games are no longer finished in isolation and then delivered to players. Instead, they are shaped through an ongoing dialogue between developers and communities.

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Image

Figure 1: Grinding Gear Games (n.d.) Grinding Gear Games, company website, accessed 27 March 2026.

<https://www.grindinggear.com/>

Figure 2: SteamDB (n.d.) Deadlock, SteamDB website, accessed 27 March 2026.

<https://steamdb.info/app/1422450/>

Figure 3: SteamDB (n.d.) Deadlock Steam Charts, SteamDB website, accessed 27 March 2026.

<https://steamdb.info/app/1422450/charts/>

Figure 4: SteamDB (n.d.) Concord Steam Charts, SteamDB website, accessed 27 March 2026.

<https://steamdb.info/app/2443720/charts/>

Figure 5: SteamDB (n.d.) Highguard Steam Charts, SteamDB website, accessed 27 March 2026.

<https://steamdb.info/app/4128260/charts/>